# *Practice Letter: Dispatch from India*

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## 【メール原文】

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Practice Letter

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India hews to US and middle powers of Global North

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I just returned from a week in India, some of it in New Delhi, where I had good access to senior government officials and policy analysts. India is focusing its foreign policy on the US; to the extent it is hedging, India is focusing on select middle powers in the Global North.

Despite a rocky 22 months since President Donald Trump took office, Indian interlocutors made it clear they place enduring, top-level value on ties with the US. Elites in New Delhi see the US as the key country for ties on economic, technical, and strategic (China) issues. Defense ties still center on Russia but are shifting toward Europe and the US.

One aspect of India's US-centered approach is the importance Indian officials attach to the bilateral trade agreement and the persistence of their negotiations. Interlocutors said that the two sides will conclude the deal shortly after the Section 301 finding is complete and India knows its final post-IEEPA tariff level. I expect the sides will finalize the trade agreement either late this year or in early 2027.

Close ties despite ongoing tensions

The upbeat Indian assessment of ties with the US is noteworthy given recent disagreements on tariffs, immigration, and geopolitical issues, including Indian purchases of Russian oil and US ties with Pakistan. Indian officials did complain about the erratic and arbitrary nature of US tariff policy. The pending trade deal should ease this friction. On geopolitics, Trump delayed new punitive tariffs on purchasers of Russian crude directed by recently passed sanctions legislation. At the same time, the Trump administration's warm ties with Pakistan will continue to irritate Indian leaders. The sides are furthest apart on immigration. The US has reduced both the availability of H-1B visas and the path to permanent residency for Indian citizens. The countries seem to be compartmentalizing this issue so it does not undermine broader ties.

I found the degree of emphasis on ties with the US surprising. India's strategic vision, as frequently elaborated by Foreign Minister S. Jaishankar, stresses strategic autonomy and multi-alignment. Those terms update the language of India's earlier leadership of the Non-Aligned Movement, which stressed solidarity with the Global South. Although Indian officials still give rhetorical weight to relations with developing countries, those ties are clearly secondary to relations with the US and developed countries.

An ideological group of Indian analysts is more anti-US. It emphasizes US decline, Trump's unacceptable treatment of India, relations with the Global South, and the need for New Delhi to take a go-slow approach on the trade agreement. It's a very hard-line but minority view.

New hedging strategy

Despite seeking close ties with the US, India is hedging—but by developing ties with countries in the Global North. New Delhi is focusing on relations with Japan, the EU, Canada, the UK, Australia, and the UAE (the only member of the Global South). Among these, Japan is the priority. These two countries are trying to strengthen supply chain security, in part by identifying areas where India's manufacturing capacity is dependent on Chinese inputs and addressing those vulnerabilities with government-backed joint ventures. Indian officials view the EU trade agreement, finalized after 20 years of talks, as a major accomplishment. In addition, India and Canada are targeting year-end to conclude a trade deal. Indian ties with the UAE, a member of the Global South, are strategic, and the Emiratis are investing heavily in India. But this relationship is an exception; New Delhi's broader focus remains on the Global North.

The implications are significant

First, India's approach undermines intra-Global South trade and governance. New Delhi's resistance to de-dollarization and other anti-US measures in the BRICS will become more entrenched. That the Global South's most influential member (I don't consider China to be an EM) is focused elsewhere suggests that new institutions governing Global South relations, if they appear, are likely to remain weak.

Second, India's policy squarely focuses on a set of middle powers of the Global North. That means India does have a large stake in the course of middle power development more broadly.

Finally, India's adherence to a pro-US policy indicates that even the erratic moves of the Trump administration have not significantly reduced India's desire to have close ties with Washington.

Happy to discuss,

Cliff

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